



DESKTOP PCS

The type of computer you buy is largely decided by the choice of its components and your budget. At the outset, there is an array of system components and even platforms to choose from. The best way to approach this decision is from the point of view of the applications you have in mind for your machine—are you going to use it for gaming or to surf the Net?

Name your brand

A Pc for gaming and entertainment would need a robust multimedia subsystem. For gaming, buy the fastest processor, the most RAM and the best graphics card your wallet permits. Also invest in a 17-inch monitor at the very least and a good sound system. The latest motherboards integrate full 5.1-channel sound and Dolby Digital soundcards are also pretty affordable now. Team up one of these sound systems with a good speaker system—go for at least a four-channel speaker system. A good system for entertainment would be one based around a 1.5 GHz processor or higher, 256 MB to 512 MB of RAM, at least a 40 GB 7,200-rpm hard disk and the best 3D accelerator card you can afford.

For Web and multimedia authoring, or system-intensive software such as page layout and image editing applications, your system should allow you to multitask effectively, with ample room for running and storing your applications and data. Go for a system with a 1.3 to 1.5 GHz processor, 256 MB RAM, at least a 40 GB hard disk and a 17-inch monitor to give you enough real estate to work the applications at higher resolutions.

For simply surfing the Net

Nominees		
Name	Contacts	Comments
HCL Beanstalk 4455	HCL Infosystems Ltd, Ph: 0120-4555219	With a 2.4 GHz Pentium 4 CPU, DDR RAM, this computer delivers good performance and also has a good set of connectivity options and peripherals
HCL Beanstalk 4458	HCL Infosystems Ltd, Ph: 0120-4555219	Running on a 2 GHz Pentium 4 CPU, DDR RAM, this computer fared well in the tests

and using e-mail, word processing and spreadsheets, a budgetary choice would be built around an 800 MHz to 1.2 GHz processor, 256 MB RAM, a 40 GB 5,400-rpm drive and a 17-inch monitor. A motherboard with integrated sound, video and networking subsystems would be quite economical here.

And the award goes to...

The computer that delivered the best performance during 2002 was the HCL Beanstalk 4455. With its best-of-breed components, it showed excellent performance in all our tests. Running on a 2.53 GHz Pentium 4 processor, 256 MB of DDR RAM, a 40 GB 7,200-rpm Seagate E7 hard disk, this PC did very well in all productivity tests. When coupled with an ATI Radeon 7500 and a 17-inch LG Iontron monitor, its gaming performance was also quite commendable. This system also had additional functionality with its 16MB cache and its 32x CD-Writer drive.



Visualan
Lavish
Visualan

Technologies,
Ph: 022-27686817

The verdict: Powered by a formidable 2.53 GHz Pentium 4 CPU, DDR RAM and an ATI Radeon 7500 graphics card, this computer performed brilliantly—ideal for processor and graphics-intensive applications



SYSTEM SUITES

Ontrack SystemSuite 4.0

The system suite most worthy of the Zero1 Award this year was Ontrack SystemSuite 4.0. This software comprises a wide array of tools and functionality to keep your system operating at its peak levels. Its good performance can also be attributed to its effective firewall and registry cleaner. This registry cleaner provides a power interface that lists duplicate and null entries from where you can delete specific entries. The firewall not only protects your computer by blocking ports but also includes functionality that makes it suited to home users.

This software presents a unique tool called EasyRecovery, which recovers permanently erased data as well as files from formatted

partitions! Another tool backs up critical system files—an invaluable feature for users who install numerous applications and expose their critical files to rogue programs. All these protective and innovative measures are available at a very reasonable price tag, spiralling Ontrack to the top pedestal.



Ontrack SystemSuite 4.0
Ontrack,
E-mail: sales@ontrack.com

The verdict: With plenty of functionality such as an integrated firewall and the ability to recover files from even deleted partitions, this suite is a must-have.

